

THE IRON LADY OF INDIAN POLITICS

Mayawati is a phenomenon, a political prodigy. The more you learn about her politics, the more you appreciate the extent to which her views and approach have had a positive bearing on the socio-political scenario of Uttar Pradesh. The first Dalit and the youngest politician elected to head a state government, little wonder if the dynamic lady trail-blazes again as the first Dalit Prime Minister of India.

In an article in the New York Times, Amy Waldman once wrote: In a state where Dalits are nearly one quarter of the population, Ms. Mayawati has used caste as a mobiliser, building on a social and political revolution 50 years in the making. It is a phenomenon that has reshaped the politics of India.

Mayawati, like any other Dalit daughter of India was deprived of many necessities of life and various privileges those other (upper class) girls of her age enjoyed. Though, like every other Dalit, she was forbidden to yet this iron-willed lady dared to dream — dream of an India free of caste discrimination, an India where castes had dissolved into classes with each of their members having individualised expressions. And to live this dream of uplifting the poor, weaker and under-privileged sections of the society, she entered Indian politics with the formation of the Bahujan Samajwadi Party in 1984.

Mayawati's journey has been tough and thorny wherein she has had to come up against huge odds. However, today she represents a very powerful voice, of the Dalits, that for long needed to be heard in Indian politics. By winning India's largest state and by successfully expanding her party's influence outside Uttar Pradesh, she has certainly become the most influential politician of recent years.

MAYAWATI...

Born in 1956 to a minor government official Prabhu Das and his wife Ram Rathi, Mayawati has been in active politics for well over two decades. Well educated, Mayawati holds multiple degrees including a B.A., a degree in education and a law degree. She worked as a teacher in Delhi for several years. Prior to her entry into the political arena, Mayawati was keen on becoming an IAS officer, a coveted position in the Indian bureaucracy.